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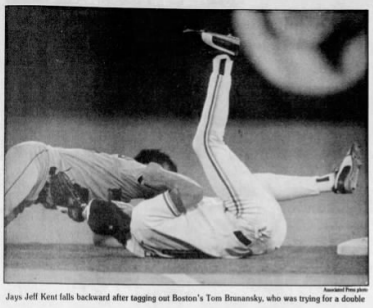

Jays Jeff Kent falls backward after tagging out Boston's Tom Brunansky, who was trying for a double

Associated Press photo

Jays' Morris out-duels Clemens

The Associated Press

Back in the days when Roger Clemens and Jack Morris were growing up, there used to be great pitching duels all the time. There was Koufax-Marichal and Gibson-Drysdale, Seaver-Carlton and Palmer-Hunter, and it seemed like they happened three and four times each season.

Nowadays, they don't have those kinds of games much. Teams don't play each other as often as they used to, and pitchers don't pitch as frequently as they did.

Once in a while, though, a nice matchup comes along worth noticing. So it was Thursday night at SkyDome when Clemens, baseball's best pitcher these days, faced Morris, baseball's reigning best big-game pitcher.

Morris beat Clemens this time, tossing a four-hitter that led Toronto past Boston 4-0. The Blue Jays won their fourth in a row and the Red Sox have lost nine of 13.

"I've faced Morris many times, and if you don't get to him early, like any top-notch starter he'll settle in and get his momentum going," Clemens said.

Clemens had been 9-0 in his previous 12 starts against the Blue Jays. But Joe Carter, Dave Winfield and Pat Borders homered off Clemens, and that was plenty for Morris.

"There's no denying he's one of the great pitchers in the game today — probably the best," Morris said. "But he's been beaten before and he'll be beaten again."

In other games, California defeated Chicago 4-0 and Baltimore downed Detroit 7-5.

Clemens (9-4) had won his last six starts overall and was leading the majors with a 1.36 ERA. He was trying to become baseball's first 10-game winner and began the game with an AL-leading 87 strikeouts.

Clemens had not lost to the Blue Jays since June 4, 1988. He beat Toronto 1-0 in April, a game in which he pitched seven innings and gave up three hits while striking out 11.

Morris (7-2) pitched his first shutout since Game 7 of the World Series last October. He walked three and struck out two in his fifth complete game of the season and his 27th regular-season shutout. He won his third straight decision.

"I don't know if I'd call this my best performance of the year," Morris said. "Maybe after the sixth inning. That's about the time all my pitches started to click."

Clemens gave up seven hits and left after Winfield's solo home run in the eighth inning made it 4-0. He struck out seven and walked three.

Carter, who homered, tripled, doubled and drove in four runs Wednesday night in New York, put Toronto ahead with a two-run homer in the third inning. Carter's 12th home run of the season came with two out.

"I liked the way I was throwing the ball," Clemens said. "But those first two runs really hurt. They were magnified in this situation because I was trying to throw zeroes."

Borders hit a solo homer, his sixth, in the seventh inning. Winfield hit his 10th home run of the season.

The Mets are failing miserably

Marty Noble
Newsday

NEW YORK — Shut out seven times in their last 24 games. Unable to win three successive games for 31 days. Burdened rather than buoyed by their bullpen. Disarmed by a finger. Damaged by schizophrenic performances by the multimillionaire cast. Undermined by the problems of last year's hero.

These are the New York Mets, the .500 Mets, 58 games into a season that has been an abject disappointment — to the men who assembled the talent, to the man who directs the personnel, to their shrinking audiences. To themselves.

No one suspected this. With all the investments and acquisitions made since last fall, the Mets thought they could be the toast of the town again. Now, two days after committing six errors in another embarrassing defeat, the glass with which this team is toasted is decidedly half-empty.

With less infighting, a stronger manager, an improved defense — the performance Wednesday night notwithstanding — and a strong effort by their veteran first baseman, the Mets have emerged from the dark ages of last summer.

But what happened since the night in Los Angeles when Bret Saberhagen's right index finger betrayed him hardly has been a renaissance. It's been digital disaster. A 4-1 victory May 15 pushed the Mets' record to 21-11. Fourteen of the subsequent 22 games have been losses, some of them demeaning and discouraging.

So instead of defending first place this weekend, the Mets only have an opportunity to reduce their deficit against the apparently recovered Pirates at Shea Stadium. Tonight's game will be televised on ESPN-Channel 7 at 4:35. Four games separate them from first place in the National League East, a position they haven't held or shared since Bobby Bonilla homered twice on Opening Night.

"To be this close the way we've played and with the two big injuries we've had is a good sign," Howard Johnson said, perhaps a tad unrealistically. But they had a chance to assert themselves last weekend in Pittsburgh as well, and fell to the occasion.

3 local players in state softball series

Melissa Huffman and Nikki Burckhardt of R.A. Long and Tiffaney Schwinn of Toutle Lake are scheduled to play in the Washington Softball Coaches Association's high school all-state series Saturday and Sunday in Wenatchee.

Huffman and Burckhardt will play for the National team in the fastpitch all-state games. Also playing will be former Longview resident Michelle Paull.

Schwinn will play for the National team in the all-state slowpitch games.

Games will be played at Walla Walla Point Park in Wenatchee.

FanFare

Snead posts course record

DEARBORN, Mich. — J.C. Snead shot a course-record 7-under-par 65 to take a one-stroke lead over Tommy Aaron after the first round of the Senior Players Championship. Defending champion Jim Albus and Don Bies set the previous record of 66 in last year's tournament.

Bob Charles, Jim Ferree and Kermit Zarley opened with 67s. Jim Colbert, Rives McBee, Dale Douglas and Butch Baird were at 68 and Albus, Lee Trevino, Dewitt Weaver and Al Geiberger opened with 70s.

Another Sutter is named

CHICAGO — Two days after his brother was appointed coach of the Boston Bruins, Darryl Sutter was named to the same position with the Chicago Blackhawks, making him the NHL's youngest coach.

The 33-year-old Sutter succeeds Mike Keenan, who will remain with the team as general manager, part of the dual post he held for two years. Brian Sutter, 36, was named coach of the Bruins on Tuesday.

Habs select Demers

MONTREAL — Jacques Demers signed a three-year contract to coach the Montreal Canadiens after spending two years away coaching as a broadcaster for the Quebec Nordiques.

The 47-year-old Demers replaces Pat Burns, who resigned two weeks ago to become coach of the Toronto Maple Leafs. Demers coached Quebec in its first NHL season, 1979-80. He worked three seasons for the St. Louis Blues from 1983-86 before moving to Detroit for the next four seasons.

Peeler waives hearing

COLUMBIA, Mo. — Former Missouri guard Anthony Peeler has waived a preliminary hearing on charges he attacked a woman he knew and held a gun to her head. The trial has been moved to Cole County Circuit Court on a change of venue, a spokeswoman for the Boone County clerk's office said.

Peeler faces three charges, including felonious restraint, in the May 30 incident at the women's apartment. The other charges involve threatening the 20-year-old woman with a gun and being found in possession of a concealed weapon by police.

Women's team is chosen

COLORADO SPRINGS, Colo. — Two-time Olympian Teresa Edwards and five others who played in the 1988 Games were named to the 12-member U.S. Olympic women's team.

Other former Olympians are Vicky Bullett, Cynthia Cooper, Katrina McClain, Suzie McConnell and Teresa Weatherspoon. Daedra Charles, Clarissa Davis, Medina Dixon, Tammy Jackson, Carolyn Jones and Vickie Orr complete the team. Jennifer Azzi, Pam McGee and Katy Steding are alternates.

Al Brightman dies

SEATTLE — Al Brightman, who put Seattle University basketball on the map in the 1950s, has died after a two-year bout with liver cancer. He was 68.

Brightman, who died Wednesday in Beaverton, Ore., compiled a 108-68 record with the Chieftains from 1949 to 1956 and took the school to six post-season tournaments — four NCAA, one NIT and one National Catholic.

He was an original member of the Boston Celtics and was the team's second-leading scorer in 1946-47 with a 9.8 point-per-game average. He also was considered a promising catching prospect for the Cleveland Indians, but an Army injury, suffered during training, ended his pro sports career.

A native of Long Beach, Calif., Brightman may best be remembered for recruiting undersized twins John and Ed O'Brien and building a nationally ranked program around them. He spotted the New Jersey brothers at the National Baseball Congress tournament in 1949 and gave them basketball scholarships before he ever saw them on a court.

But after promoting Seattle U from small-college status to a Top 20 team, Brightman and the school parted company by mutual agreement in 1956.

The issue was personal excesses.

"I was too young when I was named coach, too much of a high liver during those years," Brightman said in an interview with the Seattle Post-Intelligencer two years ago.

Gamache goes for title

PORTLAND, Maine — Joey Gamache of Maine didn't back down when the bigger kids pushed him around in the rough neighborhood where he grew up in Lewiston.

"You had to watch out for yourself. I was so small that they wanted to test you. But I never walked away from a fight," said Gamache, who has a 28-0 record with 17 knockouts.

Gamache will be using the fighting lessons he learned on the playground and in the ring when he takes on South Korean Chil-sung Chun (18-1, 11 KOs) on Saturday for the World Boxing Association lightweight title vacated by Pernell Whitaker. The fight will be televised delayed at 4:30 p.m. on ABC-Channels 2, 4.

Auburn tabs Mike Lude

AUBURN, Ala. — Auburn named Mike Lude as its new athletic director today, replacing Pat Dye.

Lude, who retired as athletic director at the University of Washington after 15 years, had been executive director of the Blockbuster Bowl.

The bowl's executive committee let Lude out of his contract to pursue the Auburn job, and today promoted assistant executive director Brian Flajole to replace him.

Lude, 69, became the front-runner for the Auburn post after Auburn president William Muse contacted him for advice about filling the vacancy.

Dye served as athletic director and football coach since 1981, but he gave up the administrative post April 30 at Muse's request. Dye retained his $146,500 annual salary.

Lude is a former president of the NCAA Division I-A athletic directors' organization and has served on several NCAA committees. That experience is seemingly a plus to Muse, who has said he wants an athletic director to get Auburn's athletics program back on track.

Boxer is 3 victories away

WORCESTER, Mass. — Oscar de la Hoya wants to follow Paul Gonzales out of East Los Angeles to Olympic glory.

"A lot of kids think there's no opportunity to get out of there," the 19-year-old boxer said.

Gonzales won the 106-pound championship at the 1988 Olympics in Los Angeles. De la Hoya is three victories away from gaining the 132-pound berth on the U.S. team that will go to Barcelona.

He was to box Lupe Suazo of Tucson, Ariz., in the semifinals of the Olympic trials Friday night at the Centrum.

The 12 trials winners will go the box-offs June 26-28 at Phoenix, where they will meet opponents selected by a committee. If a trials winner wins the first bout, he makes the Olympic team. If he loses, he must box again, with the winner making the team.

De la Hoya has been a star of amateur boxing in this country since he won a Junior Olympics title at 119 pounds in 1988.

So a lot of people were shocked when he was outpointed 17-13 by eventual champion Marco Rudolph of Germany in the second round of 1991 world championships at Sydney, Australia.

De la Hoya looks at the loss positively.

"I changed all around in my training habits," he said. "I train harder now. I hadn't lost in four years. Now I know I can lose."

The Daily News and AP

Dark clouds hang over some baseball franchises

By Peter Pascarelli
The Sporting News

Does anyone else have trouble getting excited about a season in which so many dark clouds hang over major league baseball?

The San Francisco Giants, who have lost more elections than Alf Landon, again are in limbo after another failed stadium deal. Maybe the city of San Francisco will put together a public-private funding deal to build a stadium. Maybe Owner Bob Lurie will sell the franchise to those who will move it, though who those people might be is another matter.

Commissioner Fay Vincent, mostly interested in sewing up votes for his future, criticized non-supportive fans for making it too difficult for owner John McMullen to sell the Houston Astros, a club McMullen's reduced to a bargain-basement operation by forcing his baseball people to operate under unrealistically rigid restraints. This kind of logic caused Vincent, the education commissioner, to defend that ludicrous new draft rule, saying it was created to help players graduate from college.

Attendance is down in 16 cities, though much of the drop is negligible and weather-related. The brutal fan reaction in Pittsburgh to Bobby Bonilla's departure could be a forerunner to the growing schism between multimillion-dollar players and their fans. A prominent agent says players should receive bonuses for not going on the disabled list. Labor problems beckon, and yes, George Steinbrenner will soon return.

So, have a happy rest of the 1992 season, everybody.

□□□

The White Sox have talked to several clubs about dealing knuckleball pitcher Charlie Hough. Among the interested: the Pittsburgh Pirates and Toronto. . . . People get too worked up over All-Star Game berths, but no one deserves a spot more than Philadelphia Phillies catcher Darren Daulton, who has battled injuries throughout his career to become one of the National League's best. He is the real leader of the resilient Phillies. . . .

The Boston Red Sox are trying to find takers for Jack Clark. The Red Sox want to drop his big salary, presumably to add the big salary of whatever hitter they can find. . . . Some executives think the New York Mets will get serious about finding a center fielder, which would allow them to move Howard Johnson back to the infield. Johnson's offensive production may be suffering from his move to the outfield. . . . The San Diego Padres, who need an outfielder and some lineup protection with catcher Benito Santiago out, have talked to Seattle about Jay Buhner. The Padres have no interest in Tom Brunansky or Jesse Barfield, both of whom are available.

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